

[SLIDE 1 — TITLE / OPENING]

I am Fré. I am an engineer, inventor and an entrepreneur, but I am also a member of the Belgian climbing team and one of the best climbers with a leg prosthetic in the world. In 2028 paraclimbing becomes a paralympic sport and then I want to become the first Paralympian from Leuven and bring that gold medal home.

[SLIDE 2 — THE GRIND]

For most of my childhood and early teenage years, well-meaning adults, especially the ones who didn't know me very well, would sometimes not allow me to participate in certain activities.— not because I couldn't do them, but because they assumed I couldn't. They were trying to protect me. [story schaatsen]

But they were wrong

My reaction to this was to fight back and prove that they were wrong, I threw myself into obsessive practice. I kept playing football until I was one of the best in my school, I kept pushing myself on the bike until I didn't know any other kid in the neighbourhood that could overtake me. The same was true for swimming, where I competed against abled body kids. I simply couldn't bear the thought that other people would think that I couldn't do something just because of my leg. Showing off, by being very good at things, was my way of convincing others not to exclude me from activities.

I call that period of my life My Grind.

Because of my grind, I feel I have reached a point where the term 'disabled' no longer practically applies to me. What are considered hard physical challenges for many people are well within my comfort zone. I've walked 100km in a single day. I've cycled up some of the most legendary cols of the Tour de France—the Ventoux, the Tourmalet, the Croix de Fer. I've summited 6,000-meter peaks in the Himalayas and survived weeks on a remote island during a television program called Survivor.

[SLIDE 3 — THE 4 PRINCIPLES]

My grind reshaped what my body can do. But it also reshaped what my mind can take. To get as good as others (while being disadvantaged) I had to push myself very hard and in doing so I developed a framework. A set of 4 principles that I still use today. These 4 principles helped me through a PhD in robotics, they helped me in starting up a business and now I use them to pursue my paralympic dream

The good news is, you don't need a prosthetic leg to use these principles, these principles work, even for people that have two normal legs. Especially for those with a dream they haven't yet pursued.

[SLIDE 4 — PRINCIPLE 1 TITLE]

PRINCIPLE 1 — You are not amazing, but you don't need to be.

The first principle is about believing in yourself. Yes, I am fully aware of how cringe that sounds but stay with me. Not because you are amazing, but because you don't need to be amazing to pursue your dreams. Amazing things are usually achieved by ordinary people. That's because they can be broken down into many small steps, each of which, on its own, is easy to take.

Many of you might have a dream. Maybe it's starting a business. Maybe you want to advance your career. Maybe you want to run your first marathon and some of you might want to become the best guitar player in the world. These things are definitely challenging goals. If you have never played guitar and you have to play a guitar concerto tomorrow evening, you are probably going to suck.

Here's the thing I want you to know: don't be afraid of big dreams. If your dream is actually possible, see it as the combination of many small steps that anyone can take, including you.

[SLIDE 5 — THE KULIBRIE]

My most challenging project was the development of the Kulibrie. A drone that looks like a hummingbird and flies, not by using propellers as most drones use, but by flapping its tiny little wings. It was the topic of my PhD research and it took me 6 years to develop. I had to invent everything from scratch. The flapping mechanism, the tiny electronics, the control software, everything. I had no prior knowledge of any of those, but that didn't scare me. I broke the whole development process down into tiny weekly challenges — and six years later, those weekly challenges compounded into this little fellow, something no one had ever built before.

[SLIDE 6 — PRINCIPLE 2 TITLE]

PRINCIPLE 2 — What if I tried

The second principle is about making the right choice. When I talk to people and I try to convince them to not be afraid to pursue their dreams, they often say something like, "yeah but what if I fail?". Well I have tried a lot of things and many of them failed, however I have never regretted trying any of them. Let me give an example of something that didn't work out for me. I will tell you the story of my biggest failure

From the start of my PhD I wanted to develop the Kulibrie as a product, not just as a research project, because my dream was to start a company specialised in flapping wing technology and sell millions of my little robots as toys or gadgets. I don't remember why, but for some reason that sounded like a good idea to me.

I knew it was going to be hard to sell a million of my robots. On the one hand it is a complex mechanical system that's hard to produce. It's almost like mass manufacturing a mechanical watch and on the other hand it would be a consumer product, so we had to invest a lot in marketing and set up distribution channels. The combination of hardware and consumer

product is a very tough one to pull off for a start up. I knew chances of success were thin. Every expert I talked to told me don't start.

[SLIDE 7 — THE RIGHT QUESTION]

But I tried anyway. I would have regretted it for the rest of my life if I didn't and more importantly, I asked myself the right question. Not "what if this fails?" — but "what is the worst thing that could actually happen if I did try" I would probably miss out on some other opportunities and I would lose some money. But as we soon found out, people didn't really want to buy robotic hummingbirds

So I planned the start-up in such a way that even in the worst case scenario I wouldn't be in debt for the rest of my life and then I started the company, found a business partner and for two years we gave all we had.

[SLIDE 8 — Nothing sold]

We never sold a single robotic hummingbird.

By most definitions, that's a failure. But I will never regret starting the company (it still exists by the way) and I will never have to regret not starting the company. Even more, it was probably one of the best decisions I've ever made. The reason why leads us to the third principle.

[SLIDE 9 — PRINCIPLE 3 TITLE]

PRINCIPLE 3 — THE FINAL BOSS

The third principle is about motivation. Why to do stuff.

[SLIDE 10 — THE PODIUM]

I won two World Cups and I can tell you exactly what that feels like. It feels incredible... for about five minutes. I'm serious. You're on the podium, the crowd is roaring, they are all watching you, someone hangs a medal around your neck and then they start the anthem of your favourite country, in my case that's Belgium. And then after a minute or so the music stops. You walk off the stage into the backstage and that's it. Whether or not you won the gold medal or you lost because your foot slipped off a climbing hold. You are the same person, the medal didn't change a thing and The reason is simple: An end-goal has no intrinsic value.

Whether it's a gold medal, a degree, a job title —they are just markers and if such a marker is your only motivation, you're chasing the wrong thing.

[SLIDE 11 — CHASE THE XP]

I believe you should chase something else. something that nobody can take away and something that gamers call XP or Experience points. Things like the skills you've learned, the knowledge you gained, the relationships you've built and the resilience you forged every time you tried hard and failed, but didn't give up.

For me that means: Every brutal training session? XP. Every competition where I didn't win? XP. The friends I made at competitions XP. The resilience and self-confidence forged every time I finally managed a certain climbing move after trying for a long time. That is XP.

The beauty of XP is that it doesn't disappear when the podium ceremony ends, it stays with you for the rest of your life. Whether you sold a million robotic hummingbirds or none at all. Even more, XP levels you up for bigger challenges, bigger opportunities in the future. Sometimes even opportunities you couldn't foresee.

For example, I have been climbing for over 10 years now, but only recently it was confirmed to become a Paralympic sport and I consider the Paralympics in 2028 Los Angeles as my Final Boss. It's the ultimate challenge in my sport. But here's the thing: you don't just walk up to your Final Boss and hope for the best. You need the skills. You need the knowledge. You need the experience points to be able to win. If I hadn't been collecting those XP throughout a decade, I wouldn't be standing here, ready for the challenge.

So: be motivated by the XP you gain, not a meaningless end-goal (like a million robotic hummingbirds). If you focus on the XP, you can never truly lose and on top of that the XP will prepare you for even larger challenges that one day might come across your way.

But motivation isn't enough. That's why we need a fourth and final principle. One of my best friends and the father of my god child is here in the audience today. This guy is actually one of the smartest people I know and he wrote a PhD about Gravity; I kid you not. but even he didn't know about the fourth principle:

[SLIDE 12 — PRINCIPLE 4 TITLE]

PRINCIPLE 4 — FUN disables Gravity

The fourth and final principle is about energy. To be more precise about the fact that the total energy in a closed system always stays the same. Motivation gives you the energy to be disciplined — where discipline is the ability to push through the parts of a process. The ones you don't like. For me that's eating healthy, staying away from candy and burgers. But here's the problem: discipline consumes energy. You can endure your way through something hard for a while — but it's hard to keep going if you have to rely on discipline alone. If you have to rely on discipline alone, the process will eventually take all your energy and run you out.

The solution to this is passion. Or in another word, having fun.

[SLIDE 13 — Me In Innsbruck]

In French they say — "Talent c'est dans l'envie" — talent is in the desire. If one talks about talent, people usually think of physical talent, especially in sports. like being tall for basketball, but the ability to find joy in the process is probably an even more important talent. This talent is probably the secret why some people get really good at certain things, I believe. They have the talent to enjoy every part of the process and so they don't need to waste unnecessary

energy in being disciplined. The energy they save can be redirected toward achieving excellence.

Having fun during the process is like climbing with gravity disabled. You can just keep going.

[SLIDE 14 — Birds]

But how can you find joy in a process? Well to be honest I haven't really found the full answer yet. I do believe it's easier to find joy in a process after you've tried a bit and got some expertise. A bird watcher without experience, doesn't know which birds are rare. So he can't enjoy seeing one. So give yourself some time to find the fun.

So give yourself some time to find the fun.

But on the other hand it might be that you have been dreaming about something for a while. You finally dare to take the first step, you told everybody that you want to become the greatest guitarist in history but then after a while, you discover you actually don't like to practise playing the guitar. At that point you have to be honest to yourself and just quit. That's okay. You tried and it's okay to discover that something is actually not your thing. Finding the thing that genuinely fuels you isn't giving up.

[SLIDE 15 — THE 4 PRINCIPLES RECAP]

PART 3 — THE CLOSE

Ok, let's wrap up

I told you guys about my four principles, I discovered them during my grind and I use them now to pursue my dream of becoming the first Paralympian of Leuven!

Now I share them with you, because I hope you can use them to pursue your dream. See your dream as a combination of many small steps anyone can take, then write down the first step. Just one.

And tomorrow do it. And in doing so, be motivated by the XP you gain and have fun.

Thank you

[SLIDE 16 — CALL TO ACTION / THANK YOU]